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Development of Northeast and 'Look East' Policy

Keeping in mind the strategic importance of the northeastern region and its unique and vitally important developmental needs, the Government of India set up a separate ministry for the development of northeast region (DoNER) in September 2001. Prior to that, in October 1996, the central government had put into effect a policy of earmarking at least 10 per cent of planned budgets of various central ministries or departments for the development of northeastern states. Another important step taken by the planning commission is that it allocates special plan assistance funds every year to eleven special category states, which include all the northeastern states.

Even prior to the creation of the DoNER ministry, a northeastern council (NEC) was constituted in 1971 by an act of Parliament. This high-powered apex body, comprising the governors and chief ministers of all the northeastern states, marked the beginning of a new chapter of focused and rapid development of the region. The mandate of the NEC is to take action in the fields of economic and social planning, transport and communications, and matters relating to power and flood control concerning the region as a whole. The council also has a role to review the security situation in the member states and recommend action as required. However, because of numerous reasons, most important of which is the lack of infrastructure and connectivity, the desired pace of development has not taken place. Therefore, with the active participation of all states, a comprehensive study was carried out under the aegis of the NEC